



The Pyrenees

A high natural barrier between France and Spain that has played a significant role in the history of both countries



△ BLUE RIDGES

This early morning view shows the western part of the French Pyrenees. The distinctive steep-sided peak in the foreground is Pic du Midi d'Ossau.

The Pyrenees mainly formed in the last 55 million years (see panel, below). Over time, the uplifted land was eroded, resulting in a series of parallel mountain ranges, together with some flat-topped massifs, that in places reach over 10,000 ft (3,000 m) in height.

Steep valleys and waterfalls

There are only a few places where the Pyrenees can be crossed through passes lower than 6,600 ft (2,000 m). During the last ice age, the Pyrenees experienced

extensive glaciation. The mountains are characterized by jagged peaks that are steepest on the French side. They contain some of Europe's most spectacular waterfalls, the highest of which, at the Cirque de Gavarnie, plunges 1,385 ft (422 m). Major rivers, such as the Garonne of France and tributaries of the Ebro of Spain, flow out of the mountains. Wildlife in the region includes the rare lammergeier vulture, eagles, chamois, wild boars, and a small population of brown bears.



△ SOURCE OF LEAD

The Pyrenees contains deposits of some valuable minerals, including galena (an ore of lead). The crystals seen here have unusual shapes called truncated octahedrons.

HOW THE PYRENEES FORMED

In the distant past, Iberia was an island being pushed away from Eurasia by a spreading midocean ridge. But about 70 million years ago, a new convergent plate boundary formed between Iberia and Eurasia, which began to approach each other. This led to the collision that pushed up the Pyrenees.



130 MILLION YEARS AGO



70 MILLION YEARS AGO



TODAY